point of the Saffron Revolution. The photo of Suu Kyi (the first time in four years that she had been seen in public) made international headlines. This turned what had been a mostly religious movement into a political event. The protesters gained momentum and courage from seeing Suu Kyi.

By September 23, the protests in Rangoon increased to over 20,000, making it the largest gathering since the crackdown of 1988. The tone of the protests had turned more political as chants for the release of Aung San Suu Kyi grew in intensity. The security forces did not allow a repeat of the previous day as they stopped the gathering from approaching her compound again.

Over 100,000 protesters gathered in Yangon on September 24. This was now a truly national movement including students, political opposition figures, and famous personalities. Several political organizations that had been banned began to resurface. Chants for political prisoners to be freed became the centerpiece of the activity. The red fighting peacock, a symbol of the resistance, started to reemerge. In all, 25 cities had sustained protests on September 24.

The first announcement by the government occurred on the evening of September 24. General Maung condemned the protests. The regime believed the goal of the protesters was to harm national development and stability. The government-controlled state sangha committee began a process of taking control of all Buddhists affairs. Directive 93 prohibited monks from participating in secular affairs, which amounted to banning the monks from further involvement in the protest movement. Monks and novices were also banned from joining organizations deemed illegal, such as ABMA.

The directive was part of a process that had been used numerous times in Myanmar's history to prosecute protesters and impose harsh prison terms. A more-noted police presence was in place during the evening of September 24. By the following morning, the change in tone was continuing. Additional police forces were moved into key areas and loudspeakers blared out warnings not to engage in any further protests. The nonviolent protests continued and the addition of the “fighting peacock,” a symbol from the 1988 movement, was in full view. A joint statement from the 88-generation students and the ABMA was issued encouraging the release of